

Chapter 12 - Story Book

At the same time, a white figure appeared like smoke. Chu Qingqiu clenched her palm, her eyebrows cold, standing with her back to Ning Fuyi with her hands behind her back.

"Master?" Qiu Yi, whose eyes had suddenly gone completely dark, finally managed to stand steady. She reached out to touch the ribbon on her face, but didn't dare to untie it, only standing in place in confusion. "Master, I..."

"I ordered you to bring her here secretly without alarming anyone. Is this how you don't alarm people?" Chu Qingqiu said. Her tone showed no fluctuation, but Qiu Yi, who spent day and night with her, naturally detected the hidden anger in her. Although she didn't understand, she didn't dare say more.

Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyelashes, seeming to calm her anger, and returned to her usual indifference: "Go accept your punishment."

How could Qiu Yi dare to disobey? She carefully bowed in salute, then disappeared with a "pop" sound.

Ning Fuyi was even more confused than Qiu Yi at this moment, but quickly regained her composure, curling up the corners of her mouth, seemingly casually holding the corner of the book, standing improperly.

"Greetings to the Sect Master," Ning Fuyi said with a smile.

"Put on proper clothes," Chu Qingqiu still hadn't turned around, but her tone became increasingly stern. "You also know I am the sect master. Dressed like this, what kind of behavior is this?"

Ning Fuyi looked down at herself. Her outer robe was just a bit transparent, but everything that should be covered was completely covered. At most her arms were exposed, which compared to the clothes she wore in the demon cavern in her previous life, couldn't be considered revealing at all.

Chu Qingqiu had only lived for a few thousand years now - how could she be more like an old fogey than that Chief Elder who was about to ascend to immortality?

"I understand," Ning Fuyi said lazily, then picked up the clothes hanging nearby. After a puff of smoke, she had returned to her pre-bath appearance.

Hearing that she had dressed properly, Chu Qingqiu finally turned around and looked directly at her.

"What is that thing?" Chu Qingqiu's gaze also fell on the book in Ning Fuyi's hands, her red lips slightly parted.

"A story book¹," Ning Fuyi said with her heart pounding, but her face still maintained a carefree appearance, frivolously lifting the book and shaking it.

"What story book?" Chu Qingqiu's expression was serious.

"See for yourself," Ning Fuyi held up the cover toward her, her eyes slightly curved. "What, is the Sect Master also interested in this kind of story book?"

After seeing the writing on it clearly, Chu Qingqiu's expression finally collapsed for an instant. Although she quickly covered it up, seeing it in Ning Fuyi's eyes still made her feel quite pleased.

Chu Qingqiu's mouth opened and closed, as if she wanted to say something, but in the end said nothing, only moving her gaze away and looking sternly into the distance.

"Come to my courtyard," she said, then her skirt swept up the wind as she strode away.

The moment the white figure disappeared, Ning Fuyi looked up to the sky and let out a long sigh, wiping the sweat from her forehead with her hand, holding the book to her chest and gratefully patting the cover heavily.

On it were several large characters printed in golden ink: "After Dual Cultivating² with Five Immortal Venerables Simultaneously."

Fortunately she had prepared for a rainy day, otherwise being caught by Chu Qingqiu reading forbidden books would have been somewhat troublesome.

However, now that Chu Qingqiu had found her, she naturally couldn't escape anymore and could only obediently follow her footsteps. She also wanted to see what medicine Chu Qingqiu was selling in her gourd³.

In broad daylight under the clear sky, she surely couldn't silence her, could she?

Since it wasn't time for immortal instruction yet, most disciples were still in morning cultivation, so there weren't many people on the road. Chu Qingqiu's robes billowed as she strode ahead, and Ning Fuyi had to jog to keep up.

She hated her current small frame. Standing straight, her eyes could barely see over Chu Qingqiu's shoulder. Ning Fuyi ran while snorting through her nose.

Fortunately, Chu Qingqiu didn't walk all the way to Purple Sunset Peak like this, but instead turned into a building next to Cloud Deep Hall⁴. This building had been abandoned just a few days ago, but now it had been renovated like new, with pavilions, towers, flowers, grass, and trees - everything was complete. It couldn't compare to the grandeur of the sect master's sleeping quarters, but it suited Chu Qingqiu's elegant and reclusive nature.

She walked across a stone bridge and went straight into the main hall. The hall had no doors, only a hollowed-out wooden screen. Sunlight passed through the screen, forming countless light columns that fell into the room.

Under the sunlight was placed a vermillion lacquered low table with birds and flowers, with rush mats spread on both sides. Chu Qingqiu sat down beside the table, lightly lifting her fingers, and incense on both sides ignited, sending up wisps of white smoke.

Ning Fuyi stepped over the threshold but was unwilling to go further. She leaned against the screen vigilantly, staring at Chu Qingqiu's movements.

"Why did you bring me here?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu didn't say much, but neatly waved her sleeve, and a piece of rice paper floated before Ning Fuyi's eyes. Ning Fuyi slightly raised her head and reached out to grab it in her palm.

It was a letter. Ning Fuyi recognized at first glance the flowing handwriting as Ning Changfeng's.

"Your mother wrote to me before her death, requesting that I teach you a few things," Chu Qingqiu answered.

"Asked you? To teach me?" Ning Fuyi looked at the letter suspiciously and found that what Chu Qingqiu said was true. The letter indeed spoke with earnest words, as if knowing her life wouldn't last long, like a deathbed entrustment.

Ning Fuyi stared at those lines of text, her hands trembling slightly as she read.

After a while, she waved her hand and threw down the letter, as if completely indifferent to the words on it, and laughed: "This disciple has shallow cultivation and natural stupidity. You are a dignified Divine Venerable - please don't waste your effort on this disciple."

"Moreover, whether it's me or Ning Changfeng, you've never cared about us. Why would you listen to these few last words now?" Ning Fuyi stared at Chu Qingqiu and mocked.

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu's hand holding the tea cup paused in mid-air before slowly bringing the tea to her mouth.

Ning Fuyi's fingers hidden in her sleeves kept clenching: "You could completely pretend you never saw this letter. You could continue to treat me as nothing. You only need to properly cultivate your righteous path and be your supreme Divine Venerable beloved by all people."

Just like in the previous life.

Pain came from her palm. She realized her loss of composure and loosened her grip, a faint numbness spreading from her palm.

Chu Qingqiu's long eyelashes covered her eyes. Her hand on the tea cup never moved, her fingertips seeming to tremble slightly, or perhaps Ning Fuyi was seeing things.

Just when Ning Fuyi thought she would give some explanation or reaction to her words, Chu Qingqiu suddenly stood up, her eyes showing no emotion, as if Ning Fuyi's words just now were merely a child's unreasonable tantrum.

Ning Fuyi's heart, which had been beating faster and faster, disappointedly returned to calm. She stared with a pair of pitch-black eyes at Chu Qingqiu approaching.

"Come here every morning at the hour of the dragon⁵ from now on," she said as she brushed past Ning Fuyi, a few strands of hair brushing against her neck, making her heart itch.

"How you are has nothing to do with me, but this matter was Ning Changfeng's dying request. I cannot ignore it," Chu Qingqiu stopped with her back to Ning Fuyi and added.

For some reason, Chu Qingqiu always seemed able to use the simplest words to stir up her most tremendous anger.

"What if I refuse?" Ning Fuyi suddenly turned around and retorted, "Even if I die outside tomorrow, it has nothing to do with you. Why put on this hypocritical act!"

As soon as she finished speaking, she heard the sound of wind. When she looked again, a white silk ribbon had already brushed past her temple hair and suddenly stopped at her cheek.

Ning Fuyi's breathing stopped for a moment. She fearlessly glared at Chu Qingqiu, but in a trance discovered that she, who had always been calm and unruffled, now seemed to have a slight redness at the corners of her eyes.

"When did I ever say that your life and death had nothing to do with me?" she said in a low voice.

Footnotes:

¹ Story book (话本子) - In traditional Chinese literature, these were popular fiction books, often containing romantic or adventure stories

² Dual Cultivating (双修) - A cultivation practice where two people cultivate together, sharing and enhancing each other's spiritual energy; can be platonic or intimate depending on the method

³ What medicine Chu Qingqiu was selling in her gourd (葫芦里卖的是什么药) - A Chinese idiom meaning "what her true intentions/motives are"

⁴ Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿) - A main building within the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate sect

⁵ Hour of the dragon (辰时) - Traditional Chinese timekeeping system; approximately 7-9 AM